

GE2021 Research Methods — Grading Rubrics (Fall 2026)

Assignments, Presentation, and Oral Exam

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How the rubrics work

- Every criterion is scored on a 1–10 scale using the descriptors below. Half points are not used.
- Each criterion has a weight. The assignment score is the weighted average of the criterion scores, multiplied by 10, giving a 0–100 score that is entered in the grade sheet. Example: criteria scores 8, 9, 7, 8, 6 with weights 25/20/25/15/15 → weighted average 7.75 → 77.5.
- Format and submission requirements (student ID, name, and title on the first page; no title page; academic essay format; APA 7th; PDF; file name ID_NAME_ASSIGNMENT.pdf) are scored in the last criterion of each rubric. A file that cannot be opened, is not a PDF where a PDF is required, or has no identification receives a maximum of 5 on that criterion and is returned for resubmission.
- Late work: minus 10 points per calendar day unless an extension was agreed in advance.
- Weight of each assessment in the course grade: Three Research Ideas 2%, Literature Review 2%, CITI Training 2%, Method 2%, Final Term Paper 5%, Presentation 10%, Oral Exam 25%.

Common scale (applies to every criterion)

Score	Level	Meaning
9–10	Excellent	Fully meets the requirement with precision, depth, and originality; nothing important is missing.
7–8	Good	Meets the requirement; minor gaps or imprecision that do not weaken the work.
5–6	Adequate	Requirement is addressed but superficially, unevenly, or with notable errors.
3–4	Weak	Requirement is only partly addressed; major gaps, confusion, or errors.
1–2	Missing / Unacceptable	Requirement is absent, off-task, or unusable.

1. Three Research Ideas (Research.topic, 2%)

Task. One academic essay (1–5 pages) presenting three research ideas: the idea and research questions, the motivation, what other research papers say about it, and the research purpose. Citations and a reference list are required.

#	Criterion	Weight	9–10	7–8	5–6	3–4	1–2
1	Research ideas and questions — three distinct ideas, each with a clear, answerable research question	25%	Three distinct, focused ideas; each RQ is specific, researchable, and correctly scoped	Three ideas; RQs mostly clear, one is broad or overlapping	Three ideas but RQs vague, descriptive, or not yet questions	Fewer than three ideas or RQs unclear	No usable ideas or questions
2	Motivation and significance — why each idea matters (practical or theoretical problem)	20%	Convincing, specific motivation for each idea; problem and stakeholders identified	Motivation given for each idea, some generic	Motivation stated but thin or only personal interest	Motivation missing for some ideas	No motivation
3	Engagement with prior research — what published papers say about each idea	25%	Relevant peer-reviewed sources for every idea, accurately summarized and connected to the idea	Sources for every idea; summaries mostly accurate, some loosely connected	Few sources, or sources not clearly linked to the ideas	Sources mostly non-academic or misrepresented	No sources
4	Research purpose — clear purpose statement for each idea (what the study will do and for whom)	15%	Precise purpose statements aligned with the RQs	Purpose stated, minor misalignment with RQs	Purpose vague or repeats the RQ	Purpose missing for some ideas	No purpose statements

#	Criterion	Weight	9–10	7–8	5–6	3–4	1–2
5	Writing, APA, and format — essay prose, coherent structure, APA citations and reference list, 1–5 pages, ID/name/title, PDF, file name	15%	Fluent essay; APA correct in text and list; all requirements met	Minor APA or formatting slips	Bullet-heavy or outline-like; several APA errors; one requirement missed	Hard to follow; reference list incomplete; multiple requirements missed	Not an essay; no references; wrong format

Score sheet: $\Sigma(\text{weight} \times \text{score}) \times 10 = \underline{\hspace{2cm}} / 100$

2. Literature Review Package (Literature.review.draft, 2%)

Task. Three documents: guiding table (Excel, 10–30 entries) 25%, annotated bibliography (PDF, 5–10 entries) 25%, literature review essay (PDF, 5–10 pages, APA) 50%. Each document carries student ID, name, and title.

2A. Guiding table (25% of the package)

#	Criterion	Weight	9–10	7–8	5–6	3–4	1–2
A1	Coverage and relevance — 10–30 peer-reviewed entries directly related to the research topic	35%	15+ relevant, recent, peer-reviewed entries	10–14 relevant entries, one or two marginal	10 entries but several off-topic or non-academic	Fewer than 10 entries	Table missing or unrelated
A2	Completeness of fields — citation, purpose/RQ, theory, method, sample, key findings, limitations/gap, relevance to own study	40%	All fields filled accurately for every entry	Fields filled; a few entries incomplete	Key fields (findings, gap) often missing	Mostly citations only	Empty table
A3	Accuracy and usability — correct bibliographic data, consistent entries, Excel format, ID/name/title, file name	25%	Accurate, consistent, ready to reuse	Minor inconsistencies	Several errors or inconsistent structure	Many errors; not Excel	Unusable

2B. Annotated bibliography (25% of the package)

#	Criterion	Weight	9–10	7–8	5–6	3–4	1–2
B1	Source selection — 5–10 high-quality, relevant peer-reviewed sources	25%	All sources strong and central to the topic	Sources relevant, one weak	Mix of relevant and marginal sources	Fewer than 5 or mostly non-academic	No valid sources
B2	Summary accuracy — purpose, method, and findings of each source correctly captured	30%	Precise, complete summaries in the student's own words	Accurate; some summaries thin	Summaries partly inaccurate or copied from abstracts	Summaries missing for some sources	No summaries
B3	Critical evaluation and relevance — strengths, limitations, and how each source informs the student's study	30%	Insightful evaluation and explicit link to own research for every entry	Evaluation present, links sometimes generic	Mostly descriptive, little evaluation	Evaluation absent for most entries	None
B4	APA and format — APA entries and annotations, PDF, ID/name/title, file name	15%	Correct throughout	Minor APA slips	Several APA errors	Not APA	Wrong format

2C. Literature review essay (50% of the package)

#	Criterion	Weight	9–10	7–8	5–6	3–4	1–2
C1	Organization and synthesis — themes or concepts organize the review; sources are compared and integrated, not listed one by one	25%	Clear thematic structure; sources synthesized within and across themes	Thematic structure; some sections are source-by-source	Mostly a sequence of summaries	Disorganized; no themes	Not a review
C2	Coverage and depth — breadth of relevant literature, accurate use of 10+ sources, 5–10 pages	20%	Broad, current, and deep coverage of the topic	Good coverage; a few important works missing	Narrow coverage or shallow treatment	Very few sources; under 5 pages	Insufficient
C3	Critical analysis and research gap — evaluates evidence, identifies contradictions and gaps, and derives the research question	25%	Convincing critical argument; gap clearly established and linked to the RQ	Gap identified; analysis partly descriptive	Gap asserted without evidence	No gap or RQ link	None
C4	Conceptual framework and argument coherence — key concepts defined, relationships explained, framework consistent with the review	15%	Explicit, well-justified framework consistent with the literature	Framework present, some links unexplained	Framework vague or disconnected	Concepts undefined	Absent

#	Criterion	Weight	9–10	7–8	5–6	3–4	1–2
C5	Writing, APA, and format — academic prose, APA citations and reference list, ID/name/title, PDF, file name	15%	Fluent and fully compliant	Minor slips	Bullet-heavy or several APA errors	Hard to follow; incomplete references	Non-compliant

Package score: $0.25 \times (2A) + 0.25 \times (2B) + 0.50 \times (2C)$, each part = $\Sigma(\text{weight} \times \text{score}) \times 10 \rightarrow \text{___} / 100$

3. CITI Training (IRBtraining, 2%)

Task. Complete the CITI Program course “Humanities Responsible Conduct of Research” and upload the completion certificate (PDF) named ID_NAME_CITI .pdf.

#	Criterion	Weight	9–10	7–8	5–6	3–4	1–2
1	Correct course completed — certificate shows the required course and a passing result	50%	Required course, passed, certificate valid	Required course passed; certificate partially cropped but verifiable	Different but related RCR course completed	Course incomplete (in-progress report only)	No evidence of completion
2	Certificate authenticity and completeness — learner name matches the student, completion date within the semester, record ID visible	30%	All details present and matching	One detail missing but verifiable	Name or date mismatch that needs explanation	Screenshot without verifiable details	Not a CITI document
3	Submission format — PDF, readable, ID/name on file, correct file name, on time	20%	Fully compliant	Minor naming issue	Wrong file type or unreadable pages	Multiple issues	Not submitted

Score sheet: $\Sigma(\text{weight} \times \text{score}) \times 10 = \underline{\hspace{1cm}} / 100$. Note: a valid certificate with minor format issues should still score 85 or above.

4. Method Section (Method.and.Analysis.Report, 2%)

Task. Research plan (1–5 pages) covering design, population, sample, data source and collection plan, variables, analysis method, and analytic procedure. Citations and reference list required.

#	Criterion	Weight	9–10	7–8	5–6	3–4	1–2
1	Research design — design named and justified for the research question (e.g., survey, experiment, case study, secondary data)	15%	Appropriate design, justified with methodological sources	Appropriate design, thin justification	Design named but poorly matched to the RQ	Design unclear	Missing
2	Population and sample — target population, sampling frame, sampling method, sample size with rationale	15%	All elements specified and realistic	One element vague	Population stated; sampling method or size missing	Only a vague description	Missing
3	Data source and collection plan — instruments or datasets, procedure, timeline, ethics/IRB consideration	20%	Concrete, feasible plan with instruments and ethics addressed	Plan clear; ethics or timeline brief	Plan generic; instruments not described	Plan unrealistic or incomplete	Missing
4	Variables and measurement — variables defined, operationalized, and linked to existing measures where possible	15%	Every variable defined, operationalized, and sourced	Variables defined; operationalization partly missing	Variables listed without measures	Variables unclear	Missing

#	Criterion	Weight	9–10	7–8	5–6	3–4	1–2
5	Analysis method and procedure — analytic technique suited to the design and data; step-by-step procedure; software	20%	Technique appropriate and procedure explicit	Technique appropriate; procedure sketchy	Technique named without procedure or mismatch with data	Inappropriate technique	Missing
6	Writing, APA, and format — essay prose, methodological citations, reference list, 1–5 pages, ID/name/title, PDF, file name	15%	Fully compliant	Minor slips	Bullet-heavy; several APA errors	Hard to follow; incomplete references	Non-compliant

Score sheet: $\Sigma(\text{weight} \times \text{score}) \times 10 = \underline{\hspace{2cm}} / 100$

5. Final Term Paper (Final.Paper.Chap123, 5%)

Task. Research proposal of 5–20 pages: Chapter 1 Introduction, Chapter 2 Literature Review, Chapter 3 Method, Chapter 4 Plan, Anticipated Results, and Discussion. All chapters must be consistent with one research topic.

#	Criterion	Weight	9–10	7–8	5–6	3–4	1–2
1	Chapter 1 Introduction — problem statement, motivation, purpose, research questions	15%	Compelling problem; purpose and RQs precise	Clear; minor vagueness	Problem generic; RQs weak	Introduction incomplete	Missing
2	Chapter 2 Literature Review — synthesized review, framework, and gap leading to the RQs (see Rubric 2C)	20%	Synthesized, critical, gap-driven	Organized; partly descriptive	Sequence of summaries	Thin or unrelated	Missing
3	Chapter 3 Method — design, sample, data, variables, analysis (see Rubric 4)	20%	Complete, feasible, justified	Complete; one element thin	Several elements missing or mismatched	Sketchy	Missing
4	Chapter 4 Plan, anticipated results, discussion — execution plan and timeline, expected findings tied to hypotheses/RQs, implications, limitations	15%	Realistic plan; anticipated results logically derived; implications and limitations thoughtful	All parts present; some generic	Anticipated results or discussion superficial	Chapter mostly missing	Missing

#	Criterion	Weight	9–10	7–8	5–6	3–4	1–2
5	Consistency and integration — topic, RQs, framework, method, and expected results align across chapters; revisions from earlier assignments incorporated	15%	Seamless alignment; earlier feedback visibly applied	Aligned; minor inconsistencies	Noticeable inconsistencies between chapters	Chapters read as separate papers	Contradictory
6	Writing, APA, and format — academic prose, APA in text and reference list, 5–20 pages, ID/name/title, PDF, file name	15%	Fully compliant	Minor slips	Several APA errors; length off	Hard to follow; incomplete references	Non-compliant

Score sheet: $\Sigma(\text{weight} \times \text{score}) \times 10 = \underline{\hspace{2cm}} / 100$

6. Group Presentation (presentation1, 10%)

Task. Team presentation of the assigned article. Individual scores may be adjusted for unequal contribution.

#	Criterion	Weight	9–10	7–8	5–6	3–4	1–2
1	Design — slide layout, readability, visuals, consistency, minimal text per slide	20%	Professional, visually clear, visuals support the message	Clean; a few dense slides	Inconsistent or text-heavy	Hard to read; distracting	Unprepared
2	Logic — clear storyline: purpose → key ideas → evidence → implications; smooth transitions	20%	Tight logical flow; each part builds on the last	Flow clear; one weak transition	Order confusing in places	Disjointed	No structure
3	Contents — accurate and complete understanding of the article; key arguments, method, and findings explained; critical comments	20%	Accurate, complete, and critical	Accurate; limited critique	Partly inaccurate or superficial	Major misunderstandings	Off-topic
4	Presenter performance — clarity, pace, eye contact, confidence, time management, all members contribute	20%	Confident, clear, well-timed; all members active	Clear; minor pacing or reading from slides	Reads from slides; uneven participation	Hard to follow; over/under time	Not delivered

#	Criterion	Weight	9–10	7–8	5–6	3–4	1–2
5	Effort to attract audience — engagement techniques (questions, examples, activities, discussion), audience response	20%	Creative, well-executed engagement; audience actively involved	Some engagement attempts that work	Minimal effort; passive audience	Token attempt only	None

Score sheet: $\Sigma(\text{weight} \times \text{score}) \times 10 = \underline{\hspace{2cm}} / 100$

7. Oral Exam (Oral Exam, 25%)

Task. Individual 5-minute presentation of the research proposal (final term paper) followed by questions from the instructor.

#	Criterion	Weight	9–10	7–8	5–6	3–4	1–2
1	Problem and research question — states the problem, purpose, and RQs clearly within the first minute	20%	Crisp, specific, and compelling	Clear; slightly broad	Stated but vague	Unclear	Missing
2	Literature grounding — key sources and the gap that justifies the study	15%	Gap convincingly derived from named studies	Gap stated with some sources	Generic reference to “previous studies”	No real grounding	None
3	Method — design, sample, data, variables, and analysis explained and matched to the RQ	25%	Complete and coherent; choices justified	Complete; one element thin	Several elements missing	Mismatched with RQ	Missing
4	Feasibility and contribution — realistic plan, anticipated results, and expected theoretical or practical contribution	15%	Realistic and contribution clearly argued	Realistic; contribution generic	Feasibility doubtful or contribution unclear	Unrealistic	None
5	Delivery and time management — clear speech, structure, confidence, use of visuals, within 5 minutes	10%	Polished, on time, easy to follow	Clear; slightly over or under time	Reads notes; noticeably off time	Hard to follow	Not delivered

#	Criterion	Weight	9–10	7–8	5–6	3–4	1–2
6	Response to questions — understands questions, answers accurately and thoughtfully, acknowledges limitations	15%	Precise, reflective answers demonstrating ownership of the proposal	Adequate answers; some hesitation	Partial or off-point answers	Cannot answer basic questions	No responses

Score sheet: $\Sigma(\text{weight} \times \text{score}) \times 10 = \text{___} / 100$

Appendix. Score sheet template

Assignment	Criteria (weights)	Scores (1–10)	Weighted avg	× 10 = Score
Three Research Ideas	25 / 20 / 25 / 15 / 15			
Literature Review — Guiding table	35 / 40 / 25			(×0.25)
Literature Review — Annotated bibliography	25 / 30 / 30 / 15			(×0.25)
Literature Review — Essay	25 / 20 / 25 / 15 / 15			(×0.50)
CITI Training	50 / 30 / 20			
Method	15 / 15 / 20 / 15 / 20 / 15			
Final Term Paper	15 / 20 / 20 / 15 / 15 / 15			
Presentation	20 / 20 / 20 / 20 / 20			
Oral Exam	20 / 15 / 25 / 15 / 10 / 15			

Scores entered in the grade sheet are on the 0–100 scale; the course weight (2 / 2 / 2 / 2 / 5 / 10 / 25%) is applied automatically by the grading system.